

THE SERVE

Also called the service, this stroke is the most important one to learn. Every point in a game starts with the serve. It is a tricky technique to master. Even professionals do not hit the ball over the net every time – but a server is allowed to have two attempts per point.



1 POSITION
Stand behind the baseline, just to the right of centre.



2 PREPARE
Turning sideways, hold the racket and ball in front of you.



3 TOSS
Toss the ball up and bend your racket arm back, ready to hit.



4 THROW
Throw the racket over your head and hit the ball. Follow through the stroke.

MAJOR WINNERS

The four biggest annual tennis tournaments, known as "Grand Slams", are: Wimbledon, the US Open, the Australian Open, and the French Open. Below are the top five singles Grand Slam winners.

- 1 STEFFI GRAF** Germany – 22 wins
- 2 SERENA WILLIAMS** USA – 21 wins
- 3 CHRIS EVERT** USA – 18 wins
- 3 MARTINA NAVRATILOVA** Czechoslovakia/USA – 18 wins
- 4 ROGER FEDERER** Switzerland – 17 wins

FOREHAND DRIVE

Using the forehand is the skill that tennis players learn first. With practice, it can become a very powerful stroke. The ball must bounce once before you hit it.



1 RACKET BACK
Take the racket back and up, turn your shoulders to the side, and step forwards.



2 MEET THE BALL
Swing the racket forwards to meet the ball in front of your body. Hit the ball and follow through the stroke with the racket.

FOREHAND VOLLEY

Volley shots are played close to the net. Players must hit the ball before it bounces. The action is short, fast, and punchy, and does not use a big swing.



1 REACH
Stretch out your racket arm and step forwards. Watch the ball all the time.



2 SHORT FOLLOW-THROUGH
After making contact with the ball, finish the stroke with a short follow-through.

THE SMASH

The smash shot uses an action similar to that of the serve. It hits the ball as it comes down from high in the air, and requires fast thinking. You may have to spring up to reach the ball. Fully stretch your racket arm and reach up with the other arm. Drop the racket head behind your back and then accelerate it forwards to hit the ball.

Turn your body sideways and position yourself under the ball



Reach up with your opposite arm

BACKHAND DRIVE

You play this stroke when your opponent hits the ball towards the side opposite your racket arm.

1 SWING BACK
As the ball comes, turn your shoulders to the side and swing your racket back.



2 STEP
With a firm grip on the racket, step forwards to meet the ball. Stretch out your racket arm to hit the ball in front of your body.

3 FOLLOW THROUGH
Keeping the swing going, follow through the shot with your racket. Do not take your eyes off the ball until it is safely over the net.

Turn your shoulders to the side as you take the racket back



DOUBLE-HANDED BACKHAND
Two hands can give extra strength and power a backhand drive.

BACKHAND SLICE

Once you have mastered the basic backhand, you can try the more challenging backhand slice. A ball hit with this stroke spins and lands low, so it can take your opponent by surprise.



1 BACK
Take the racket back as you would for the backhand drive, with the head angled slightly up.



2 SLICE
Step into the shot and slip the head of the racket under the ball. Hit the ball when it is just in front of your body.



3 FOLLOW-THROUGH
Keep your arm straight and follow through with a short chopping movement. This part of the stroke is important, as it drives the ball forwards.